

Travel and Expenses Claim Pack — Finance Office

Finance Office, Expenses Section
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To the claimant,

This pack accompanies your overseas travel expense claim. It gathers in one document everything the Expenses Section refers to when a claim is checked: the Travel and Expenses Policy, the rate tables in force for the period of travel, the guide to completing the claim form with a worked specimen, the claim form itself, the receipt index, the approval routing, the standard letters you may receive, and the audit and appeals arrangements.

Only the claim form in Section 4 is to be completed. Every other section is for reference. Please check the form against the policy before submission: the commonest reasons for a claim being returned are a missing receipt, an expense type that does not match the receipt, and a subsistence claim that overlaps a meal already included in a conference fee or hotel rate.

Claims are processed in order of receipt. A complete claim is normally paid in the payroll run following approval; a claim returned for correction re-enters the queue on resubmission.

Expenses Section

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Section 1. Travel and Expenses Policy

This policy applies to all staff, research students and visitors who incur expenses on University business and seek reimbursement from University funds, whatever the source of those funds. It sets out what may be claimed, the evidence required, the limits that apply, and how claims are approved and paid. Grant-funded travel is additionally subject to the terms of the grant; where the funder's rules are stricter than this policy, the funder's rules apply.

1.1 Principles

1. Expenses are reimbursed only where they were necessarily incurred in the performance of University duties and were reasonable in amount.
2. The University reimburses actual cost against receipts, except where this policy provides a flat-rate allowance. An allowance may not be claimed in addition to the actual cost it replaces.
3. Travel must be by the most economical means consistent with the purpose of the journey and the reasonable convenience of the traveller. Where a more expensive option is chosen for personal reasons, the difference is borne by the traveller.
4. The claimant certifies that every item claimed was incurred on University business and has not been, and will not be, claimed from any other source.
5. The approver certifies that the travel was authorised, that the expenses are consistent with this policy, and that the funds are available in the cost centre charged.
6. No person may approve his or her own claim, a claim from a person to whom he or she reports, or a claim in which he or she has a personal interest.

1.2 Authorisation before travel

All overseas travel requires written authorisation before booking, using the travel authorisation form or the equivalent workflow in the finance system. The authorisation records the purpose of the journey, the destination, the dates, the estimated cost, and the cost centre to be charged. Travel booked without prior authorisation is reimbursed only where the head of department confirms in writing that it would have been authorised had it been requested; repeated instances are reported to the Dean.

Where the traveller will also take personal leave in the destination, the authorisation must state the business dates separately, and only expenses attributable to the business dates are reimbursed. Airfare is reimbursed in full where the fare would have been the same without the personal days; otherwise the traveller bears the difference.

1.3 Booking

Airfares and accommodation should be booked through the University's appointed travel agent, which applies the class-of-travel and accommodation-cap rules automatically and invoices the University directly. Where the agent cannot offer an itinerary that meets the requirements of the journey, the traveller may book directly and claim, keeping evidence that the agent's quotation was compared. Bookings made through online platforms must be supported by the platform's receipt showing the traveller's name, the dates and the amount paid, not merely a booking confirmation.

1.4 Class of travel

Air travel is in economy class for all journeys. Premium economy may be authorised by the Dean for a single flight sector exceeding eight hours where the traveller is required to work on the day of arrival, and business class only where a medical condition certified by the University's occupational health service

makes economy travel unsuitable. Rail travel is in standard class; first class may be used where it is cheaper at the time of booking. The class of travel entitlements are summarised in Section 2.3.

1.5 Accommodation

Accommodation is reimbursed at actual cost up to the nightly cap for the destination shown in Section 2.2, inclusive of taxes and service charges but exclusive of meals, minibar, laundry, telephone, film and other personal charges. Where the conference hotel exceeds the cap, the excess is reimbursed if the traveller can show that no suitable accommodation within the cap was available within reasonable distance of the venue. Accommodation with friends or family may be claimed at the flat rate in Section 2.2 without receipts.

1.6 Subsistence

Subsistence covers meals and incidental expenses while away from the normal place of work overnight. It is paid at the flat daily rate for the destination shown in Section 2.1, for each night spent away, without receipts. The rate is reduced by one third for each main meal provided by a conference, a host or a hotel rate. Subsistence is not paid for days on which the traveller was on personal leave. For journeys without an overnight stay, actual meal costs may be claimed against receipts up to the day-trip limit in Section 2.1.

1.7 Local transport

Public transport, airport transfers, taxis where public transport is impractical or unsafe, and hire cars where authorised are reimbursed at actual cost against receipts. A multi-day transport pass is reimbursed in full where it is cheaper than the single fares it replaces. Mileage for the use of a private vehicle is paid at the rate in Section 2.4 and requires the journey log on the claim form.

1.8 Conference and registration fees

Registration fees are reimbursed against the organiser's receipt. Where the fee includes meals or accommodation, the subsistence and accommodation claims for the corresponding days are reduced accordingly. Membership fees of a society are not reimbursed as an expense even where membership reduces the registration fee; they may be charged to a research account where the funder permits.

1.9 Other business expenses

Items such as printing of research posters, shipping of equipment or specimens, visa fees, vaccination costs required for the destination, and business telephone and internet charges while away are reimbursed against receipts where they were necessary for the purpose of the journey. Items of equipment purchased while travelling remain University property and must be recorded in the departmental inventory on return.

1.10 Non-reimbursable items

- Alcohol, other than a moderate amount with a meal that is itself reimbursable under a hospitality authorisation.
- Personal entertainment, fitness or spa charges, films, and newspapers.
- Travel insurance purchased privately; the University's policy covers all authorised travel.
- Parking fines, speeding fines, and any other penalty.
- Costs of a spouse, partner or other accompanying person.
- Upgrades of any kind chosen by the traveller.
- Tips and gratuities above 10 percent of the underlying charge.

- Loss of personal cash or property.
- Charges arising from a failure to cancel a booking that was no longer needed.

1.11 Receipts and evidence

Every item claimed, other than a flat-rate allowance, must be supported by an original receipt or an electronic receipt showing the supplier, the date, the amount, and the nature of the goods or service. Credit card statements and booking confirmations are not receipts. Where a receipt has been lost, the missing-receipt declaration in Section 5 must be completed and countersigned by the approver; the Expenses Section may refuse an item where declarations are used repeatedly. Receipts in a language other than English or Chinese should be annotated with a short description of the item.

1.12 Foreign currency

Expenses incurred in a foreign currency are converted to Hong Kong dollars at the University's monthly rate for the month in which the expense was incurred, published in Section 2.5. Where the traveller can show, by a card statement, the actual rate charged, that rate may be used instead. Exchange commission and foreign transaction fees charged by the traveller's bank are reimbursable against the statement showing them.

1.13 Advances

A cash advance may be requested for overseas travel where the estimated out-of-pocket cost exceeds HK\$ 5,000. The advance is deducted from the claim; where the claim is less than the advance, the balance must be repaid within 14 days of return. No further advance is issued while an earlier advance remains unaccounted for.

1.14 Timing

Claims must be submitted within 60 days of the return date. Claims submitted later than 60 days require the written approval of the head of department with an explanation of the delay, and claims submitted later than six months after the return date are not reimbursed except in exceptional circumstances approved by the Director of Finance. Expenses incurred in one financial year must be claimed in that year where possible; the year-end cut-off is announced each June.

1.15 Approval and payment

Each claim is approved by the budget holder of the cost centre charged, within the delegated limits in Section 6, and is then checked by the Expenses Section for compliance with this policy. Payment is made by bank transfer to the claimant's salary account in the payroll run following approval. Where a claim is charged to more than one cost centre, each budget holder approves his or her share.

1.16 Audit

The Expenses Section examines every claim for arithmetic, receipts and policy compliance, and Internal Audit examines a sample of approved claims each quarter. Findings are reported to the head of department and, where a claim was approved in breach of this policy, to the Director of Finance. Amounts paid in error are recovered from the claimant through payroll. Deliberate misstatement of a claim is treated as gross misconduct under the disciplinary procedure.

1.17 Fieldwork and hazardous travel

Fieldwork away from an established institution, and travel to a destination for which the Security Bureau has issued an outbound travel alert, require a risk assessment approved by the head of department before authorisation. The risk assessment covers the itinerary, local contacts, communication arrangements, medical facilities, and the actions to be taken if the traveller cannot be contacted.

Expenses that arise from the mitigation measures in an approved risk assessment — satellite communication hire, a local guide or driver, additional accommodation nights for acclimatisation — are reimbursable against receipts even where they would otherwise fall outside this policy. Travel to a destination under a red or black alert is not authorised except by the Vice-President (Research) on the recommendation of the University's security adviser.

1.18 Insurance

All authorised travel is covered by the University's group travel insurance, which provides medical expenses, emergency evacuation, personal accident, loss of baggage and travel documents, and cancellation cover arising from illness, bereavement or the withdrawal of a conference. The cover applies from departure to return and includes up to seven days of personal leave taken in conjunction with the business travel. Claims under the insurance are made to the insurer, not through the expense claim; the Finance Office issues the policy summary and the emergency assistance number with each authorisation. Where a loss is not recoverable under the insurance — for example an excess, or an item excluded by the policy — it is not reimbursable as an expense either, except where the head of department accepts that the loss arose directly from the performance of University duties.

1.19 Grant-funded travel

Travel charged to an external grant is subject to both this policy and the funder's terms. The principal investigator is responsible for confirming, before authorisation, that the travel is an allowable cost under the grant, that it falls within the grant period, and that the budget line has sufficient balance. Where the funder's rules are stricter — a lower subsistence rate, a requirement for receipts for every item, a prohibition on business-class travel in any circumstance — the stricter rule applies and the difference cannot be charged to another University fund. Where the funder's rules are more generous, this policy still applies. The commonest funder restrictions are summarised below; the grant terms themselves prevail.

Funder type	Subsistence	Receipts	Class of travel	Timing
Research Grants Council (general research fund)	University rate	Required over HK\$ 200	Economy only	Within grant period
Innovation and Technology Fund	University rate, capped at 90% of published civil-service rate	Required for all items	Economy only	Within project period; pre-approval for overseas
Overseas government funders	Funder's own per diem tables	Funder's rules	Economy; premium with written approval	Funder's reporting period
Industry sponsors	As stated in the agreement	As stated in the agreement	As stated in the agreement	Agreement period
Charitable foundations	University rate unless capped	Required for all items	Economy only	Within award period

1.20 Hospitality while travelling

A meal or refreshment offered to an external guest while travelling — a collaborator, a prospective recruit, a funder's representative — is hospitality, not subsistence, and requires the hospitality authorisation on the claim form to be completed with the names and affiliations of the guests and the business purpose. Hospitality is reimbursed at actual cost against an itemised receipt up to the per-head limit of HK\$ 600 for a meal and HK\$ 120 for refreshments, inclusive of a moderate amount of alcohol with a meal. The claimant's own share of a hospitality meal is claimed as hospitality and the subsistence rate for that day is reduced accordingly.

1.21 University procurement cards

Holders of a University procurement card may pay travel expenses with the card where the supplier accepts it. Card transactions are not claimed on the expense form; they are reconciled monthly through the card statement, with receipts attached to the statement and the same policy limits applied. Subsistence, which is a flat-rate allowance, cannot be paid with the card and is claimed on the expense form in the usual way. Cash withdrawals on the card are not permitted except in an emergency notified to the Finance Office within one working day.

1.22 Sustainable travel

The University reports the carbon emissions of business travel and expects travellers to consider whether a journey is necessary, whether the purpose could be achieved by video conference, and whether rail is practicable for journeys under six hours. The travel authorisation records the traveller's assessment. Where rail is available at a total cost within twenty percent of the air fare and the journey time is within six hours, rail is the expected mode and air travel requires the head of department's approval. Carbon offsets purchased privately are not reimbursable; the University offsets centrally.

1.23 Visiting scholars and external examiners

Visitors whose travel is paid by the University are reimbursed under this policy on the visitor claim form, which follows the same layout as form EXPGEN2 but pays to a nominated bank account rather than a salary account. A visitor without a Hong Kong bank account is paid by telegraphic transfer, and the transfer charge is borne by the University. Visitors are asked to submit claims within 30 days of the visit so that departmental budgets can be closed.

1.24 Booking through the appointed travel agent

The appointed agent holds the University's negotiated fares and hotel rates and applies this policy at the point of booking. Bookings are made by e-mail or through the agent's online portal using the traveller's University account, quoting the travel authorisation number. The agent issues an itinerary and an invoice to the cost centre; the traveller receives an e-ticket and, for hotels, a voucher. Changes and cancellations are made through the agent, which advises the fare rules and any charge before confirming.

Fare rule	What it means for the traveller	Policy position
Non-refundable	No refund if cancelled; taxes may be recoverable	Default for conferences with fixed dates
Changeable with fee	Dates may be changed on payment of a fee plus fare difference	Preferred where dates may move; fee reimbursable where the change was for business reasons
Fully flexible	Refundable and changeable without fee	Only where the head of department confirms the itinerary is genuinely uncertain
Basic economy (no bag, no seat selection)	Lowest fare; baggage charged separately	Acceptable; baggage charge reimbursable
Codeshare	Ticket issued by one carrier for a flight operated by another	Acceptable; the operating carrier's baggage rules apply
Open-jaw	Arrival and departure at different cities	Acceptable where it serves the itinerary

Where the agent's fare is more than fifteen percent above a fare the traveller has found elsewhere for the same itinerary and fare rule, the traveller may book directly and claim, attaching a screenshot of both fares taken on the same day. The Finance Office reviews these comparisons quarterly with the agent.

1.25 Hotel bookings and no-shows

Hotel bookings through the agent are guaranteed to the University's account and invoiced after the stay. A booking that is not cancelled by the hotel's deadline and not used is charged as a no-show; the charge is borne by the cost centre where the failure to cancel was outside the traveller's control, and otherwise

by the traveller. Extra nights added at the hotel by the traveller are settled by the traveller and claimed with the hotel's receipt.

Section 2. Rate Tables (in force for travel from 1 January 2026)

2.1 Overseas subsistence — flat daily rate, HK\$ per night away (meals and incidentals)

Destination	Rate	Destination	Rate
Australia - Melbourne	610	Japan - Tokyo	640
Australia - Sydney	630	Korea - Seoul	560
Canada - Toronto	590	Netherlands - Amsterdam	600
Canada - Vancouver	580	Singapore	570
China - Beijing	480	Spain - Barcelona	540
China - Shanghai	500	Sweden - Stockholm	620
France - Paris	620	Switzerland - Geneva	700
Germany - Berlin	560	Switzerland - Zurich	710
Germany - Munich	580	Taiwan - Taipei	470
Italy - Milan	580	United Kingdom - London	680
Italy - Rome	570	United Kingdom - Manchester	590
United States - Boston	660	United States - New York	720
United States - San Diego	620	United States - San Francisco	700
Other destinations	500	Day trip without overnight stay (against receipts)	up to 300

The rate is reduced by one third for each main meal provided. Nights are counted from the date of departure to the date of return; a journey of five nights is paid at five times the rate regardless of the time of arrival on the last day.

2.2 Accommodation — nightly cap, HK\$ inclusive of taxes

Destination	Cap	Destination	Cap
Australia - Melbourne	1,500	Japan - Tokyo	1,600
Australia - Sydney	1,700	Korea - Seoul	1,300
Canada - Toronto	1,500	Netherlands - Amsterdam	1,700
Canada - Vancouver	1,500	Singapore	1,600
China - Beijing	1,100	Spain - Barcelona	1,400
China - Shanghai	1,200	Sweden - Stockholm	1,700
France - Paris	1,800	Switzerland - Geneva	2,100
Germany - Berlin	1,500	Switzerland - Zurich	2,200
Germany - Munich	1,700	Taiwan - Taipei	1,100
Italy - Milan	1,600	United Kingdom - London	2,000
Italy - Rome	1,500	United Kingdom - Manchester	1,400
United States - Boston	2,000	United States - New York	2,400
United States - San Diego	1,800	United States - San Francisco	2,300
Other destinations	1,300	Staying with friends or family (flat rate, no receipt)	250

2.3 Class of travel entitlement

Mode	Standard entitlement	Exception	Approver for the exception
Air, any sector	Economy	Premium economy where a single sector exceeds 8 hours and work is required on arrival	Dean
Air, any sector	Economy	Business class on certified medical grounds	Director of Finance
Rail	Standard class	First class where cheaper at booking	None required
Ferry	Economy	Cabin on overnight crossings	Head of department
Hire car	Compact or intermediate	Larger vehicle where 4 or more travel together or equipment is carried	Head of department
Taxi	Where public transport impractical, unsafe, or unavailable	—	None required

2.4 Mileage and other flat rates

Item	Rate
Private car, per kilometre	HK\$ 4.20
Motorcycle, per kilometre	HK\$ 1.80
Bicycle, per kilometre	HK\$ 0.90
Passenger supplement, per passenger per kilometre	HK\$ 0.40
Home working allowance while abroad for more than 14 days, per week	HK\$ 150
Overnight incidental allowance within Hong Kong (no meals), per night	HK\$ 120

2.5 Monthly exchange rates — HK\$ per unit of foreign currency

Month	EUR	GBP	USD	JPY (per 100)	AUD	SGD	CNY	KRW (per 1,000)
October 2025	8.47	10.18	7.78	5.14	5.05	6.02	1.09	5.62
November 2025	8.42	10.10	7.78	5.09	5.02	6.00	1.09	5.58
December 2025	8.40	10.05	7.78	5.03	5.00	5.98	1.08	5.51
January 2026	8.36	9.98	7.78	4.98	4.97	5.95	1.08	5.47
February 2026	8.39	10.02	7.78	5.01	4.99	5.97	1.08	5.50
March 2026	8.41	10.07	7.78	5.05	5.01	5.99	1.09	5.53

Rates are the mid-market rate on the first working day of the month, published by the Finance Office. On the claim form the rate is entered to four decimal places.

2.6 Country notes for frequently visited destinations

The notes below are maintained by the Finance Office with the University's travel agent and security adviser. They summarise entry requirements, health precautions and local practice that affect what a traveller may need to claim. They are not a substitute for the official advice of the destination's consulate, which the traveller should check before booking.

Destination	Entry	Health	Local practice affecting claims
Germany	Visa-free for HKSAR passport holders up to 90 days in the Schengen area; ETIAS authorisation expected to apply from 2026	No vaccinations required; European Health Insurance Card not available to non-EU travellers, so insurance card must be carried	City tax added to hotel bills is reimbursable; transport passes (day, week, month) are usually cheaper than singles from the second day
United Kingdom	Visa-free up to 6 months; Electronic Travel Authorisation required from 2025	No vaccinations required	Hotel VAT is included in the rate and reimbursable; rail fares vary widely by booking time — advance tickets expected
United States	ESTA required for visa-waiver travel; apply at least 72 hours before departure	No vaccinations required	Hotel rates exclude tax and resort fees, which are reimbursable; tipping of 15–20% is customary and reimbursable within the 10% policy limit only up to that limit
Japan	Visa-free up to 90 days	No vaccinations required	Consumption tax is included in prices; IC transit cards are refundable and the deposit is not claimable
South Korea	K-ETA may be required; check before booking	No vaccinations required	Hotel rates usually include tax and service; taxis are inexpensive and receipts are printed on request
Singapore	Visa-free up to 30 days; SG Arrival Card required	No vaccinations required	Goods and services tax is reimbursable; hotel service charge is included in the rate
Australia	Electronic visa (ETA or eVisitor) required	No vaccinations required; strict biosecurity on food and biological samples	Goods and services tax is reimbursable; accommodation in Sydney regularly exceeds the cap during conference season — pre-authorise
Mainland China	Visa or permit as applicable to the traveller's document	No vaccinations required	Fapiao (official receipt) must be obtained for every item; a card slip is not accepted
Switzerland	Visa-free up to 90 days in the	No vaccinations required	Hotel guest cards often include free public

	Schengen area		transport — claim no transport pass where one is provided
Canada	eTA required for air arrivals	No vaccinations required	Provincial sales taxes are reimbursable; rates in Vancouver exceed the cap in summer — pre-authorise

2.7 Worked examples of subsistence reductions

Situation	Nights	Rate	Reduction	Amount claimed
Research visit, no meals provided	4	560	None	2,240.00
Conference, breakfast included in hotel rate every night	3	680	$1/3 \times 680 \times 3 = 680.00$	1,360.00
Conference, breakfast and conference lunch on two days	3	620	$1/3 \times 620 \times 3 + 1/3 \times 620 \times 2 = 1,033.33$	826.67
Host provides all meals	5	480	Full	0.00
Personal leave on two of six nights	4 (business)	600	None on business nights	2,400.00
Day trip, no overnight stay	0	—	Actual meals against receipts	up to 300.00

Amounts in this table are illustrations of the arithmetic at the 2026 rates and do not relate to any particular claim.

2.8 Typical airfare bands used for authorisation estimates (economy, return, HK\$)

Route	Low season	High season	Notes
Hong Kong – Singapore	2,200 – 3,500	3,500 – 5,000	Frequent daily services
Hong Kong – Tokyo	3,000 – 4,500	4,500 – 7,000	Peak in cherry-blossom season and Golden Week
Hong Kong – Seoul	2,500 – 3,800	3,800 – 5,500	—
Hong Kong – Sydney	5,500 – 8,000	8,000 – 11,000	Peak December–January
Hong Kong – London	7,000 – 10,000	10,000 – 14,000	Direct services daily
Hong Kong – Frankfurt or Berlin	7,500 – 11,000	11,000 – 15,000	Berlin usually via Frankfurt or Munich
Hong Kong – Paris	7,500 – 11,000	11,000 – 15,000	—
Hong Kong – Zurich	8,000 – 11,500	11,500 – 15,500	—
Hong Kong – San Francisco	7,000 – 10,500	10,500 – 14,000	—
Hong Kong – New York	8,500 – 12,000	12,000 – 16,000	Direct services limited; via West Coast common
Hong Kong – Toronto	8,500 – 12,000	12,000 – 16,500	—

Bands are indicative and drawn from the travel agent's bookings in the previous year. They are used to check the estimate on a travel authorisation, not to cap the fare claimed.

2.9 Overseas subsistence and accommodation — full destination list (HK\$)

The tables in 2.1 and 2.2 list the most frequently visited destinations. The full list follows. Where a city is not listed, the country rate applies; where the country is not listed, the Other destinations rate applies.

Destination	Subsistence per night	Accommodation cap	Destination	Subsistence per night	Accommodation cap
Austria - Vienna	590	1,600	Malaysia - Kuala Lumpur	420	900
Belgium - Brussels	600	1,700	Mexico - Mexico City	480	1,200
Brazil - São Paulo	520	1,300	Netherlands - Rotterdam	570	1,500
Canada - Montreal	560	1,400	New Zealand - Auckland	560	1,400
Chile - Santiago	500	1,200	New Zealand - Wellington	550	1,300
China - Guangzhou	460	1,000	Norway - Oslo	700	1,900
China - Hangzhou	450	1,000	Philippines - Manila	400	900
China - Shenzhen	470	1,100	Poland - Warsaw	480	1,200
Czech Republic - Prague	500	1,300	Portugal - Lisbon	520	1,400
Denmark - Copenhagen	680	1,900	Qatar - Doha	620	1,600

Finland - Helsinki	640	1,700	Saudi Arabia - Riyadh	600	1,600
France - Lyon	560	1,400	Singapore	570	1,600
Germany - Frankfurt	580	1,600	South Africa - Cape Town	460	1,100
Germany - Hamburg	560	1,500	Spain - Madrid	550	1,400
Germany - Berlin	560	1,500	Sweden - Gothenburg	600	1,600
Greece - Athens	500	1,200	Switzerland - Basel	690	2,000
Hungary - Budapest	470	1,100	Switzerland - Lausanne	690	2,000
India - Bengaluru	400	1,000	Thailand - Bangkok	420	900
India - Mumbai	430	1,100	Turkey - Istanbul	470	1,100
India - New Delhi	420	1,000	United Arab Emirates - Abu Dhabi	640	1,700
Indonesia - Jakarta	410	900	United Arab Emirates - Dubai	660	1,800
Ireland - Dublin	640	1,800	United Kingdom - Cambridge	640	1,700
Israel - Tel Aviv	660	1,800	United Kingdom - Edinburgh	610	1,600
Italy - Bologna	540	1,300	United Kingdom - Oxford	640	1,700
Italy - Florence	560	1,400	United States - Atlanta	620	1,700
Japan - Kyoto	600	1,500	United States - Chicago	660	1,900
Japan - Osaka	590	1,400	United States - Houston	600	1,600
Korea - Busan	520	1,200	United States - Los Angeles	680	2,100
Korea - Daejeon	500	1,100	United States - Seattle	670	2,000
Macau	450	1,100	United States - Washington DC	700	2,200

Effective for travel from 1 January 2026. Rates are reviewed annually against the civil-service subsistence tables and the travel agent's average booked hotel rates for the previous year.

Supplement A — Travel Risk Management and Overseas Travel Insurance

A.1 Purpose and Scope

This supplement sets out how the University assesses and manages the risks of travel undertaken outside Hong Kong for teaching, research, external engagement and other approved University business, and how the University's group travel insurance operates alongside the Travel and Expenses Policy. It is provided for reference: it does not create any additional form to complete, and nothing in it changes the claim form in this pack or the rates that apply to subsistence and accommodation. A traveller who has questions about how a specific itinerary should be assessed, or about what the insurance would cover in a particular circumstance, should raise them with the Head of Department or the Safety and Security Office before departure rather than after a loss has occurred, since several of the arrangements described below depend on steps being taken in advance of travel.

The supplement applies to all staff, postgraduate research students and other persons travelling on University business with prior authorisation, whether the journey is a short visit of a few days or an extended placement of several months. It does not apply to travel undertaken in a purely personal capacity, even where it is combined with University business, except to the extent that personal days are formally attached to an authorised itinerary. Where a journey combines duties for more than one department, or is jointly funded, responsibility for the risk assessment and for insurance registration rests with the department that authorises the earliest leg of the itinerary, which should coordinate with the other departments named on the authorisation before departure.

The University owes a duty of care to everyone it sends abroad on its business, and that duty does not stop at the border or end once a claim has been paid. The arrangements in this supplement exist because a problem that arises while someone is travelling for the University — an illness, a lost passport, an accident, a security incident — is a University matter as much as a personal one, and the University is better placed than an individual traveller to have thought in advance about how such a problem would be handled. None of this is intended to make travel feel burdensome: the great majority of trips proceed exactly as planned, and the point of preparing for the small minority that do not is precisely so that the rest can proceed without a second thought.

A.2 Pre-travel Risk Assessment

Before any journey outside Hong Kong is authorised, the traveller and the Head of Department consider together whether the itinerary raises risks beyond those of routine travel, and if so how those risks will be reduced. This pre-travel risk assessment looks at the whole journey rather than a single flight or hotel booking: it considers the route and any transit points, the standard of accommodation and transport that will be used, the reliability of communication along the way, the distance from consular or medical support, and the pattern of activity planned once the traveller arrives, including any time spent away from a host institution.

For most journeys the assessment is a short conversation recorded in a few lines on the travel authorisation, confirming that the destination and itinerary present no unusual risk beyond what a competent traveller would expect to manage. For a longer placement, a journey with several stops, or an itinerary that includes fieldwork, remote sites or physically demanding activity, the assessment is set out in writing using the risk assessment form maintained by the Safety and Security Office, and is reviewed and signed by the Head of Department before the trip is authorised.

1. Confirm the purpose, dates and full itinerary of the trip, including any internal legs and transit points.
2. Check the latest advisory and health information available for each stage of the itinerary.
3. Identify any activity, location or mode of transport that raises the level of risk above routine travel.

4. Agree the mitigations needed, such as a communication schedule, additional insurance registration, or a change of accommodation or route.
5. Record the assessment and obtain the Head of Department's sign-off before the trip is authorised.
6. Brief the traveller on the emergency assistance arrangements and the reporting duties described later in this supplement.

A pre-travel risk assessment is not a one-off exercise filed and forgotten. It is reviewed whenever the itinerary changes materially after authorisation — an added stop, an extended stay, a change of accommodation to a location the Head of Department has not seen, or a deterioration in the situation at the destination reported through the advisory information the University monitors. The assessment and any later revision are kept with the travel authorisation for the retention period that applies to travel records generally, so that they can be referred to if an incident is later reported.

A.3 Travel Requiring Higher-Level Approval

Some journeys need approval above the Head of Department before they are authorised. The University does not fix this by naming particular countries or cities, because conditions change and a single place can present very different levels of risk depending on the specific itinerary, the time of year and the activity planned. Instead, the need for higher-level approval is judged against a small number of criteria that the Safety and Security Office applies consistently across all destinations, drawing on the advisory information it monitors and on the detail of the pre-travel risk assessment.

The criteria include the level of an official travel advisory current at the time of booking, the reliability of medical and emergency evacuation capability along the planned route, the stability of the security environment reported for the period of travel, the reliability of communication with the traveller once they arrive, and whether the itinerary places the traveller in a remote location without ready access to consular support. A journey that meets one of these criteria strongly, or several of them to a moderate degree, is treated as requiring higher-level approval regardless of how routine the destination might otherwise seem.

- An official travel advisory at or above the level at which the University treats travel as non-routine.
- Limited or unpredictable access to emergency medical treatment or evacuation along the planned route.
- A security environment reported as unstable or rapidly changing for the period of travel.
- Communication with the traveller expected to be intermittent or unavailable for extended periods.
- An itinerary that places the traveller in a remote area for a significant part of the trip, away from consular or institutional support.

Where one or more of these criteria applies, the Head of Department refers the travel authorisation, together with the pre-travel risk assessment, to the Safety and Security Office, which may in turn refer it to the Vice-President (Administration) for a final decision. The referral records what mitigations are proposed — for example a local escort, a satellite communication device, a shortened stay, or a change to daytime-only movement — and the decision is communicated back to the Head of Department before the trip can be authorised. A decision is not treated as a formality: the reviewing officer may ask for the itinerary to be changed, for additional equipment to be hired, or, in a small number of cases each year, may decline to authorise the trip as planned.

Where approval is declined or delayed, the department and the traveller consider whether the purpose of the trip can be achieved another way — by remote participation, by rescheduling to a period when conditions are expected to have improved, or by sending a different member of staff whose presence does not depend on the same personal circumstances. A decision to decline authorisation is not a

judgement on the importance of the underlying work; it reflects the University's duty of care and is recorded in the same way as any other travel authorisation decision.

A.4 The Emergency Assistance Service

Every traveller on authorised University business outside Hong Kong has access to a round-the-clock emergency assistance service operated on the University's behalf by its insurer. The service is reached through a single international number printed on the insurance card issued with each travel authorisation, and it operates in multiple languages so that a traveller can be understood even where local language skills are limited. It is intended to sit alongside, not replace, local emergency numbers: where there is an immediate threat to life, the traveller or a companion should still contact the local emergency service first and then notify the assistance line as soon as it is safe to do so.

The service can arrange or coordinate a wide range of support once notified: it can direct a traveller to an approved medical provider and guarantee payment so that treatment is not delayed by a request for cash or a card; it can organise medical evacuation or repatriation where a treating doctor judges it necessary; it can help replace a lost or stolen passport by liaising with the nearest consulate; it can provide interpretation for a medical or legal conversation; and it can act as a point of contact for a traveller's family while the University's own channels are also kept informed.

1. A medical emergency, hospital admission, or a condition that may require evacuation to receive adequate treatment.
2. Loss or theft of a passport, visa documents or other essential travel documents.
3. A security incident affecting the traveller directly or the area in which they are staying.
4. A natural event, civil disturbance or transport disruption that prevents the traveller from continuing or completing the planned itinerary.
5. Any situation in which the traveller is uncertain whether local help is adequate and would value a second point of contact.

Registering the itinerary with the assistance service before departure means that, if the traveller cannot make contact themselves, the service already has enough information to begin locating them. The Safety and Security Office registers routine itineraries in batches from the travel authorisation records; a traveller whose plans change materially after registration, or who is added to a trip at short notice, should confirm directly with the office that the change has been picked up, since the service can only act on the information it has been given.

Reference: [as shown on the acknowledgement] Date: [date of issue]

Notice to Staff and Postgraduate Research Students

From the Safety and Security Office

Registering your itinerary before you travel

Once your travel authorisation has been approved, your basic itinerary is passed to the emergency assistance service automatically. If your plans change after that point — a different flight, an added stop, a change of hotel, or an extension of your stay — please let this office know before you leave, or as soon as you can once you are travelling. A short message with your updated dates and location is enough; a new form does not need to be completed. Keep the insurance card issued to you with you at all times while you are away, and make sure at least one person at home knows how to reach this office on your behalf if you cannot be contacted directly.

Safety and Security Office

A.5 What the University's Travel Insurance Covers

The University's group travel insurance covers a traveller from the point of departure from their home or normal workplace to the point of return, for the whole of an authorised journey outside Hong Kong. In broad terms it provides for the cost of emergency medical treatment and hospital care abroad, including treatment that continues after the traveller would otherwise have returned; for medical evacuation and repatriation where a treating doctor judges this necessary; for a personal accident benefit; for costs arising from the cancellation or cutting short of a trip for a covered reason such as the traveller's own illness, a close bereavement, or the cancellation of the event that the trip was arranged around; for the loss, theft or damage of baggage and personal effects up to the policy limit; and for a personal liability benefit if the traveller is held responsible for injury or damage to a third party while travelling.

Cover follows the whole of the authorised itinerary, and extends to a reasonable period of personal leave taken immediately before or after the business dates, provided the leave was declared on the travel authorisation and does not substantially change the risk profile of the trip. A traveller who adds leave after the authorisation has been approved should let the Head of Department know, both so that the authorisation record is accurate and so that the insurance registration reflects the actual dates of travel.

Certain medical conditions must be declared before departure for treatment relating to them to be covered; the declaration is made through the Safety and Security Office at the time the travel authorisation is submitted, and is treated confidentially. Where a condition is declared, the insurer may set a specific condition on cover, such as requiring the traveller to carry a defined quantity of medication or to register with a specific evacuation provider; the office will tell the traveller of any such condition before the trip is authorised.

Where treatment is received abroad, the traveller or a companion should keep the paperwork the local provider issues — the admission record, the discharge summary, an itemised bill — because the insurer will ask for this before it settles directly with the provider or reimburses the traveller. The emergency assistance service can explain what a particular provider will need and can, in many cases, deal with the paperwork directly with the provider so that the traveller does not have to.

A.6 What the Travel Insurance Excludes

The policy does not respond to every loss that occurs while travelling. It generally excludes a loss connected with travel undertaken against a current official advisory unless the trip was specifically authorised at the higher level described in A.3 with that advisory taken into account; a loss connected with recreational activity that is hazardous by its nature — technical mountaineering, diving beyond a recreational qualification, motor sport — unless it was declared and accepted as part of an approved fieldwork plan; and a loss connected with the traveller's own intoxication or with a criminal act on the traveller's part.

It also excludes a medical condition that existed before travel and was not declared where the policy requires declaration, a loss arising during a period of personal leave that was not declared on the travel authorisation, and a loss of cash or of items of unusually high personal value that were not separately declared before departure. A traveller who wishes to carry an item of significant value — a specialist instrument, for example, that belongs to the traveller personally rather than to the University — should ask the Safety and Security Office whether it needs to be separately declared.

An excluded loss is not automatically reimbursable as a business expense either. Where a traveller believes an excluded loss nonetheless arose directly from the performance of University duties — for example equipment damaged while assisting a host institution with an activity that was part of the agreed programme — the Head of Department may exercise the same discretion described in the main policy

for a loss that is not recoverable under the insurance, but this discretion is the exception rather than the rule and is not a substitute for insurance cover that could have been arranged in advance.

A traveller who is unsure whether a planned activity would fall within an exclusion is better served by asking the Safety and Security Office before departure than by assuming the activity is covered because it seemed a natural part of the trip. Where the answer depends on how the activity is arranged — whether a guide is qualified, whether equipment meets a recognised standard — the office can often suggest a small change that brings the activity within cover rather than simply confirming that it would otherwise fall outside it.

A.7 Incident and Medical Emergency Reporting

A traveller involved in, or witness to, an incident while on University business overseas has a duty to report it once immediate safety has been addressed. A reportable incident includes any injury requiring medical treatment beyond simple first aid, any hospital admission, any security incident directed at the traveller or affecting the place they are staying, any significant loss of University property, and any near miss that could easily have resulted in one of these outcomes. The duty to report applies even where the traveller does not intend to make an insurance claim, because the report itself feeds into how future risk assessments are prepared.

1. Attend to immediate safety and obtain local medical or emergency help if it is needed.
2. Contact the emergency assistance service described in A.4 for support with treatment, evacuation or replacement documents.
3. Notify the Head of Department, or in their absence the Dean, as soon as it is practicable to do so.
4. Complete the incident notification form maintained by the Safety and Security Office with as full an account as can reasonably be given at the time.
5. Cooperate with any follow-up review, including a request for further detail needed to support an insurance claim.

Stage	Responsible	Action	Timeframe
Immediate response	Traveller	Ensure personal safety and seek local medical help if needed, then contact the emergency assistance service	Immediate
Initial notification	Traveller or their contact	Notify the Head of Department and the Safety and Security Office	Within 24 hours
Written account	Traveller	Complete the incident notification form with a full account	Within 5 working days
Risk review	Head of Department	Assess whether the risk assessment needs updating	Within 10 working days
Insurer notification	Safety and Security Office	Pass details to the insurer where a claim may arise	Within 5 working days
Welfare follow-up	Safety and Security Office	Confirm the traveller's welfare and any support needed	Ongoing until resolved

Once the immediate response has been dealt with, the Safety and Security Office arranges any welfare support the traveller may need, which can include help arranging a change of return flight, a referral for confidential support, or continued contact while the traveller remains away. Support of this kind is arranged case by case and is not conditional on the traveller having done everything exactly as this supplement describes; the priority in the days after an incident is the traveller's welfare, and any question about whether reporting was timely or complete is addressed afterwards, separately, as part of the review.

Incident reports, stripped of anything that would identify the individual traveller, are reviewed periodically by the Safety and Security Office to see whether a pattern is emerging that should change how future

risk assessments are prepared for similar journeys — a route that has produced more than one report, an activity that keeps appearing in incident reports, or a gap in the guidance that a traveller has pointed out. This is one of the main ways in which the risk assessment described in A.2 is kept current rather than static.

A report made in good faith is not treated as an admission that something was done wrong, and a traveller is not discouraged from reporting a near miss simply because nothing ultimately went wrong. The Safety and Security Office would rather receive several reports of situations that resolved themselves without harm than none at all, because a near miss reported early is often the clearest warning that a particular route, activity or arrangement needs a closer look before someone is less fortunate.

A.8 Travelling with University Equipment and Data

A traveller who carries University equipment — a laptop, a specialist instrument, material collected for onward analysis — is responsible for a basic level of care appropriate to the value and sensitivity of what is being carried. Before departure, the department maintains a short record of what equipment has left with whom and when it is expected back, separate from any inventory kept for other purposes, so that a loss can be identified and reported quickly and so that the equipment is not mistaken for missing stock while the traveller is still away.

Where a trip involves handling data — research data, personal data about research participants, or other material that would cause harm if it were lost or accessed without authorisation — the traveller is expected to carry as little of it locally as the work allows, favouring secure remote access to systems based in Hong Kong over copies held on a laptop or portable drive. Where a local copy is unavoidable, it is encrypted to the standard set by the University's information security guidance, and the traveller does not use the copy on a shared or public computer. A lost or compromised device is reported to the University's information security team without delay, in addition to the insurance and safety reporting described elsewhere in this supplement, because the two kinds of report trigger different responses.

Some equipment and some categories of technical data are subject to export control or to the import rules of the destination, independent of anything in this supplement. A traveller who is not sure whether an instrument, a component, or a dataset falls into a controlled category should check with the department responsible for export control compliance before packing it, since the check can take longer than expected and cannot always be completed at short notice at the airport.

Loss of or damage to University equipment while travelling is usually covered by the same insurance arrangements described in A.5, subject to the same exclusions in A.6, but the practical replacement of the item — ordering a new one, reissuing access credentials, restoring data from a backup — is handled by the department in the normal way once the loss has been reported, and does not wait for the insurance claim to be settled.

A.9 Lone Working and Fieldwork Travel

Travel undertaken alone, or fieldwork carried out away from a host institution's main site, carries a different pattern of risk from a journey where the traveller is met, hosted and accompanied throughout. Before this kind of trip is authorised, the Head of Department agrees with the traveller how contact will be maintained, who will notice if a scheduled check-in is missed, and what that person should do if it is.

The usual arrangement is a simple check-in schedule agreed before departure — for example a message at the start and end of each working day during a period of fieldwork, or at agreed intervals during a longer solitary journey. A missed check-in triggers an escalation that starts with an attempt to reach the traveller directly, moves to their local contact or host if there is one, and, if there is still no word

after an agreed interval, moves to the Safety and Security Office, which decides whether to involve the emergency assistance service.

- A communication device appropriate to the area, tested before departure, with the check-in schedule agreed and understood by both the traveller and the named contact at home.
- A route or work plan shared with the department and, where relevant, with a local host, updated if it changes materially.
- Basic local emergency contact information for the specific area, not only the national emergency number.
- A plan for what happens if the traveller is unreachable for longer than the agreed interval, including who is contacted next.

Fieldwork in a physically demanding or remote setting adds further preparation beyond the check-in arrangement: confirmation that the traveller is medically fit for the activity planned, a check of any specialist equipment needed for the environment, and, where the work depends on a local guide, porter or driver, some assurance that the arrangement is a reputable one rather than one found only on arrival. Departments that send staff or students into this kind of fieldwork regularly are expected to keep a short written note of how these checks are normally carried out, so that the same questions do not have to be worked out afresh for every trip.

None of this removes the traveller's own judgement once they are on the ground: a check-in schedule and a shared plan are there to catch the case where something has gone wrong, not to substitute for ordinary caution about a route, a contact or a situation that does not feel right. The Head of Department remains available to be contacted for a decision about changing or shortening a trip while it is under way, and would rather be asked than not.

Preparatory task	Responsible	When it is done
Agree the check-in schedule and escalation contact	Traveller and Head of Department	Before the travel authorisation is signed
Confirm fitness for the planned activity	Traveller, with the University's health service where relevant	Before departure
Test communication equipment and confirm coverage along the route	Traveller	In the week before departure
Share the route or work plan with the department and any local host	Traveller	Before departure, and again if it changes
Record local emergency contact information for the specific area	Traveller, filed with the Safety and Security Office	Before departure

A.10 Personal Safety While Travelling

Most of the harm that befalls a traveller on University business has nothing to do with the destination's advisory level and everything to do with ordinary carelessness of a kind that could happen almost anywhere: a bag left unattended in a lobby, a wallet visible in a back pocket on crowded transport, a return to unfamiliar accommodation late at night on foot rather than by an arranged or clearly licensed vehicle. None of this needs a formal assessment to manage, but it is worth setting out plainly because it accounts for a disproportionate share of the incident reports the Safety and Security Office reviews each year.

A traveller carrying a University laptop, a payment card and identity documents together in one bag is more exposed than one who splits them between hand luggage and a bag kept close on the body, and a traveller who photographs the picture page of a passport and stores it separately from the original recovers far more quickly from a loss than one who has not. Hotel safes are used for documents and cards not needed for the day's activity, and a room number is not announced within earshot of strangers

at reception. Where a local host offers to arrange transport after an evening event, that offer is usually the safer option, and a traveller declining it should have a specific, trusted alternative already arranged rather than relying on hailing something on the street.

None of this is intended to make a traveller anxious about ordinary movement in a place that presents no elevated risk; the overwhelming majority of University travel passes without incident of any kind. It is intended to make the small, low-cost precautions habitual, in the same way that checking for a hotel's nearest fire exit on arrival is habitual for a frequent traveller, so that they are already in place if something less ordinary does happen.

A.11 Health Preparation Before Departure

A traveller with a regular prescribed medication carries enough for the whole trip plus a reasonable margin in case of delay, keeps it in hand luggage rather than checked baggage, and carries it in its original packaging together with a note from a prescribing doctor describing the condition and the dosage, since this can be needed to satisfy a customs check or to support a replacement prescription obtained abroad. A traveller who is not sure whether a particular medication is freely importable at the destination should check before departure rather than on arrival, because the answer can depend on the specific compound rather than on the condition it treats.

The University's health service can advise on recommended precautions for a specific itinerary, including whether any vaccination should be considered given the season and the nature of the activity planned, and can usually see a traveller at short notice where a trip has been arranged quickly. This advice is separate from, and additional to, the pre-travel risk assessment described in A.2: the risk assessment looks at the journey and the activity, while the health service looks at the traveller's own health in the context of that journey.

A traveller with an ongoing health condition that could affect, or be affected by, the planned activity is encouraged to mention it confidentially to the Safety and Security Office when the risk assessment is prepared, not because it will usually change whether the trip goes ahead, but because knowing about it in advance lets the emergency assistance service respond faster and more appropriately if it becomes relevant while the traveller is away. A traveller is never required to disclose more than is relevant to the specific journey, and a disclosure made for this purpose is not shared with the Head of Department beyond what is needed to authorise the trip safely.

A traveller returning from a period of fieldwork in a remote setting, or from a placement affected by an incident of any kind, is encouraged to attend a short check with the University's health service on return, even where nothing appeared wrong during the trip itself. Some conditions relevant to travel become apparent only after return, and a check made as a matter of routine, rather than only when something is already troubling the traveller, catches these earlier and more reliably.

A.12 Support for Staff Travelling with Additional Needs

A traveller who needs a particular seating arrangement, a specific type of accommodation, or additional time to move between connections because of a disability, a temporary injury, pregnancy, or another additional need, should say so when the trip is first proposed rather than once bookings have already been made, so that the University's appointed booking channel can look for an itinerary that works rather than adjusting one that does not. Raising this early is treated as entirely routine and is not something a traveller needs to justify beyond describing what would help.

Where an additional need increases the cost of an itinerary — a direct routing instead of one with a difficult connection, a room closer to a lift, an earlier arrival to allow rest before an activity begins — that additional cost is authorised as part of the trip rather than treated as a discretionary extra to be queried afterwards, provided it is reasonably connected to the need described. The Head of Department

authorising the trip is expected to treat such a request in the same way as any other planning detail, and to raise any question about it with the traveller directly and promptly rather than leaving it unresolved close to the departure date.

A traveller who becomes unwell, is injured, or otherwise finds their circumstances have changed while already travelling is not expected to manage a change of plan alone: the emergency assistance service described in A.4 can help rearrange onward travel or accommodation, and the Head of Department can authorise a change to the itinerary from a distance without waiting for the traveller to return before the change is agreed.

Where a need is likely to recur across several trips rather than arising once, the traveller and the Head of Department are encouraged to agree a standing note of what works well, so that the same ground does not need to be covered from scratch before every journey. A standing note of this kind belongs with the traveller, not with a single trip's paperwork, and travels with them to a new department if their University affiliation changes.

A.13 Returning from Travel and Debrief

For most trips, returning to Hong Kong ends the arrangements described in this supplement: the insurance registration lapses at the point of return, and there is nothing further for the traveller to do beyond the ordinary business of submitting the expense claim in this pack. For a trip that was authorised at the higher level described in A.3, that involved an incident of any kind, or that took the traveller into sustained fieldwork or remote conditions, the Head of Department has a short conversation with the traveller once they are back, separate from anything connected to the expense claim itself.

This return conversation is deliberately informal. It asks whether the risk assessment prepared before departure matched what was actually encountered, whether the check-in or communication arrangement worked as intended, and whether anything happened, however minor, that the traveller thinks a colleague making a similar trip in future should be told about. A traveller is never at fault for a risk assessment that turns out, with hindsight, to have understated a difficulty that could not reasonably have been foreseen at the time; the purpose of the conversation is to improve the next assessment, not to review the traveller's own judgement.

Where the conversation surfaces something that other departments sending staff on similar journeys would benefit from knowing, the Head of Department passes a short, anonymised note to the Safety and Security Office, which maintains the country and route notes referred to in A.2 and A.3. In this way the experience of one traveller feeds quietly into the preparation given to the next, without any need for a traveller to write a formal report unless they would find it useful to do so.

A.14 Coordinating with a Host Institution's Own Arrangements

A traveller working at a host institution, laboratory or partner site for any length of time is expected to follow that host's own on-site safety rules and any local induction it provides, in addition to, not instead of, the arrangements described in this supplement. Where the host's rules are stricter than the University's own guidance — a requirement to wear specific protective equipment, a restriction on working alone in a particular area, a curfew on site access — the stricter rule applies for the duration of the visit, and a traveller who is unsure which rule takes precedence follows whichever is more cautious rather than assuming the University's is the default.

If an incident occurs while the traveller is at a host site, the traveller follows the host's own immediate response procedure first, since the host is best placed to manage what happens on its own premises, and then meets the reporting duty described in A.7 to the University separately and without delay. The two reports are not a substitute for one another: a host institution's own incident record does not reach

the Safety and Security Office automatically, and a traveller who assumes it will has not met the duty to report described in this supplement.

Where a host institution's own information security or data handling rules differ from the University's, the traveller applies whichever set of rules gives the greater protection to the data or equipment concerned, and raises any conflict between the two with the department responsible for information security before relying on the host's arrangements alone. A collaboration or visiting agreement negotiated before the trip is a good opportunity to settle this kind of question in advance, rather than leaving it to be worked out informally once the traveller has already arrived.

A.15 Keeping This Supplement Up to Date

This supplement is reviewed by the Safety and Security Office at least once a year, and sooner if the insurer changes a material term of the policy or if a pattern in incident reports points to a gap in the guidance. Where a change affects a trip already authorised, the Head of Department is notified directly rather than relying on the traveller to notice a revised edition of the handbook. Questions about how a specific provision applies to a specific itinerary are always better raised before departure than worked through afterwards, and the Safety and Security Office would rather answer what may turn out to be an unnecessary question than receive a report that a step was missed because nobody was sure who to ask.

A department that finds it is asking the Safety and Security Office the same question repeatedly for similar trips is encouraged to say so; a recurring question is usually a sign that this supplement should be clearer on that point, and the annual review is the natural point at which such feedback is worked into the next edition rather than left to be answered afresh each time it comes up.

Section 3. Guide to Completing the Claim Form

The claim form (form EXPGEN2) has a header block, a receipts table, a subsistence table, and a declaration. Complete it in the order below. Amounts are entered in Hong Kong dollars with cents; foreign amounts are entered in the receipt currency with the exchange rate alongside.

3.1 Header

- Name: as held on the staff record, surname first, exactly as it appears on the payslip. The finance system matches the claim to the payroll record by name and staff number.
- Staff number and cost centre: from the payslip or the departmental office. The cost centre determines who approves the claim; a wrong cost centre routes the claim to the wrong approver and delays it.
- Purpose and justification: state the business purpose in full, naming the conference, host institution or project, and the agreement or grant under which the travel took place. Claims giving only a city name are returned.
- Destination: from the list in Section 2.1, in the form Country - City. Where the destination is not listed, write Other destinations and name the city in the justification.
- Type of claim and reimbursement currency: Overseas Travelling for any journey outside Hong Kong; the reimbursement currency is always HKD.

3.2 Receipts table

- One line per receipt, in date order. The receipt date is the date on the receipt, not the date of travel; for an airfare it is the date of purchase.
- Expense type: choose from the list printed on the reverse of the form (and reproduced in the glossary, Section 9). Airfare, accommodation and local transport are Travelling types; registration fees are Conference types; anything that fits no type is Others, with a description that makes the item clear.
- Description: what was bought, from whom, and for how long where relevant — for example the route and carrier for an airfare, the hotel and number of nights for accommodation.
- Receipt currency and amount: exactly as printed on the receipt. Exchange rate: from Section 2.5, to four decimal places; 1.0000 for HKD receipts. Reimbursable amount: receipt amount multiplied by the rate, rounded to the cent.

3.3 Subsistence table

- One line per destination. The expense type is Travelling - Subsistence Allowance. Start and end dates are the dates of departure from and return to Hong Kong; nights is the number of nights between them.
- The amount is nights multiplied by the rate in Section 2.1, less one third of the rate for each meal provided. Note any meals provided in the description.

3.4 Advance, declaration and submission

Enter any advance received; the finance system deducts it. Sign and date the declaration. Attach the receipts in the order of the table, numbered to match, and submit the form to the departmental office, which forwards it to the approver. Electronic submission through the finance system is available to departments enrolled in the pilot; the rules are the same.

3.5 Frequently asked questions

The hotel included breakfast. What do I claim?

Claim the room rate in full up to the cap, and reduce the subsistence claim by one third of the daily rate for each night on which breakfast was provided. Note breakfast included in the subsistence description.

My flight was paid by the travel agent. Do I list it?

No. Items invoiced directly to the University are not claimed; they are already charged to the cost centre. List only what you paid yourself.

I paid in euros on a card. Which rate do I use?

Either the monthly rate in Section 2.5 for the month of the receipt, or the actual rate on your card statement if you attach the statement. Use one method for the whole claim.

I lost the receipt for a taxi.

Complete the missing-receipt declaration in Section 5 for that item and have the approver countersign it. Taxi items under HK\$ 100 may be declared without countersignature.

Can I claim the conference dinner?

If the dinner was part of the registration fee, it is already paid; reduce subsistence for that day. If it was an optional ticket, it is reimbursable only where attendance served a business purpose confirmed by the approver.

The claim is for a trip six months ago.

Attach the head of department's written approval and an explanation of the delay. Claims older than six months are not paid except with the Director of Finance's approval.

The conference organiser paid my hotel directly.

Do not claim it. Reduce your subsistence for any meals the organiser provided and note the arrangement in the justification.

I extended the trip by three days of leave.

Claim the airfare in full if the fare would have been the same for the business dates alone, and attach the agent's confirmation that it was. Claim accommodation and subsistence only for the business nights. Give both sets of dates in the justification.

Two of us shared a hotel room.

One traveller claims the whole room charge; the other claims nothing for accommodation and notes the arrangement. Both claim subsistence.

I paid for a colleague's taxi as well as my own.

Claim the whole fare and list the colleague's name in the description. The colleague claims nothing for that journey.

The airline charged for checked baggage.

A baggage charge on an economy fare is part of the airfare and is claimed as Travelling - Airfare (Basic Economy Class) with the receipt. Excess baggage for equipment is claimed as Others with the reason stated.

Do I need to convert receipts myself?

Yes. Enter the receipt currency and amount, the rate to four decimal places, and the converted amount. The Expenses Section re-performs the arithmetic and will correct a rounding difference of less than one dollar without returning the claim.

What counts as a night?

A night away is counted for each date of departure up to but not including the date of return. Depart on the 2nd and return on the 7th: five nights.

Where do I find my cost centre?

On the payslip, in the top right, or from the departmental office. Grant-funded travel uses the grant's cost centre, which the principal investigator will give you; it is not the department's teaching or research-pool code.

Can I submit a claim for a trip that has not finished?

No. A claim covers a completed journey. For a long placement, interim claims may be submitted monthly with the head of department's agreement, each covering a completed calendar month.

Who signs if my head of department is away?

The deputy head, or the Dean, as the delegated authority table in Section 6 provides. An approval by a person without delegated authority is not valid and the claim is returned.

3.6 Worked specimen

The following pages show a specimen claim form completed for an imaginary two-night conference trip, to illustrate how each block is filled in. The particulars are fictitious and are printed for guidance only. Do not copy any value from the specimen into your own claim.

SPECIMEN — FOR GUIDANCE ONLY — NOT A CLAIM

UNIVERSITY FINANCE OFFICE EXPENSES CLAIM FORM — TRAVEL AND SUBSISTENCE <i>To be completed in BLOCK CAPITALS by the claimant. Original receipts must be attached. Please read Notes 1 to 4 below before completing.</i>	EXPGEN2 FO RL 22 4 25 SPECIMEN — FOR GUIDANCE ONLY
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For the Period: **From 1 January 2026 To 3 January 2026 Claim Reference: TEC-0000-0000**
 Type of Claim: **Overseas Travelling**

Surname SAMPLE	Forenames Specimen	Payroll No 00000000	National Insurance No AA 00 00 00 A
Name of Claimant (as held on the staff record) Sample Specimen	Post Held Post title as on the staff record	Telephone Extension 0000 0000	Cost Centre to be charged 00000
Department Department (as on the staff record)	E-mail specimen@example.edu	Home Address 1 Example Road, Example Estate, Kowloon	
Reason for payment / Justification of expense claim (Note 1) Conference — Example: presentation of an accepted paper at the International Conference on Example Studies, London. Destination: United Kingdom - London.			

SUMMARY OF CLAIM
Enter the total for each category below. Full details of every item must be given in the Analysis of Expenditure overleaf (Note 2). Categories with no expenditure are to be left blank.

NB	Category of expenditure — please give full details overleaf	HKD	cents
	Air travel	1,000	00
	Rail and other travel	—	
	Accommodation	2,000	00
	Conference and registration fees	200	00
	Subsistence	—	
	Other incidentals (receipts attached)	—	
	** TOTAL INCURRED (HKD)	4,200	00
	If you received an advance please enter amount >>>>	Nil	
	BALANCE DUE TO THE CLAIMANT	4,200	00

ANALYSIS OF EXPENDITURE (Note 3)

Expenditure Date	Expense Type	Details of expenditure	Currency	Amount (foreign currency)	Exchange Rate	Amount HKD
01-JAN-2026	Travelling - Airfare (Basic Economy Class)	Example return airfare HKG-LHR	HKD	1,000.00	1.0000	1,000.00
01-JAN-2026	Travelling - Accommodation	Example hotel, 2 nights	GBP	200.00	10.0000	2,000.00
02-JAN-2026	Conference - Other Conference Expenses	Example poster printing	GBP	20.00	10.0000	200.00

SUBSISTENCE CLAIMED

Expense Type	From	To	Destination	Details	Nights	Amount HKD
Travelling - Subsistence Allowance	01-JAN-2026	03-JAN-2026	United Kingdom - London	Meals and incidentals (breakfast provided, reduced)	2	1,000.00

Name of Bank Example Bank Limited	Account Name SAMPLE SPECIMEN	Account No 000-000000-000	Sort Code 00-00-00
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Bank details are required only where they differ from those held on the payroll record (Note 4).

DECLARATION

I certify that the expenditure detailed above was incurred by me wholly, exclusively and necessarily in the course of University business, that the receipts attached are originals, and that no other claim has been or will be made in respect of these items.

Signature of Claimant Date

AUTHORISATION

I certify that funds are available against the cost centre shown and that this claim complies with the University's travel policy. The authorising signatory must be senior in status to the claimant.

Authorised by (PRINT & SIGNATURE) Date

Cost Centre	GL Code	WBS Element	SIO	VAT Code	Checked
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FOR FINANCE OFFICE USE ONLY — DESCRIPTION FOR POSTING TO AGRESSO

Note 1. State the business purpose of the travel in full. Claims giving only a destination will be returned.

Note 2. Categories are pre-printed. Leave a category blank where no expenditure was incurred against it.

Note 3. Where expenditure was incurred in a currency other than HKD, state the amount in the original currency together with the rate applied. The market rate published on the first day of travel may be used for the whole trip.

Note 4. Claims received more than 60 days after the end of travel must be accompanied by a written explanation.

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END OF SPECIMEN — the particulars above are fictitious.

Section 4. Claim Form (completed)

The claim form for this journey follows on the next page. It was completed by the claimant from the receipts listed in Section 5 and is the source of every value to be entered when the claim is lodged in the finance system. The specimen in Section 3.6 is an illustration only and must not be used.

UNIVERSITY FINANCE OFFICE

EXPENSES CLAIM FORM — TRAVEL AND SUBSISTENCE

To be completed in BLOCK CAPITALS by the claimant. Original receipts must be attached. Please read Notes 1 to 4 below before completing.

EXPGEN2

FO RL 22 4 25

For the Period: From 03 December 2025 To 06 December 2025

Claim Reference: TEC-2026-0608

Type of Claim: Overseas Travelling

Surname LAM	Forenames Ka Yee	Payroll No 00187425	National Insurance No SN 62 30 41 A
Name of Claimant (as held on the staff record) Lam Ka Yee	Post Held Postdoctoral Fellow	Telephone Extension 3411 9037	Cost Centre to be charged
Department Department of Applied Physics	E-mail ky.lam@univ.edu.hk	Home Address Room 512, Postgraduate Hall 3, University Campus	
Reason for payment / Justification of expense claim (Note 1) Training — Attendance at the Advanced Synchrotron Techniques short course, Australian Synchrotron, Melbourne. Charged to the departmental training allocation. Destination: Australia - Melbourne.			

SUMMARY OF CLAIM

Enter the total for each category below. Full details of every item must be given in the Analysis of Expenditure overleaf (Note 2). Categories with no expenditure are to be left blank.

NB	Category of expenditure — please give full details overleaf	HKD	cents
	Air travel	7,860	00
	Rail and other travel	—	
	Accommodation	1,464	90
	Conference and registration fees	2,467	20
	Subsistence	—	
	Other incidentals (receipts attached)	—	
	** TOTAL INCURRED (HKD)	13,472	10
	If you received an advance please enter amount >>>>	Nil	
	BALANCE DUE TO THE CLAIMANT	13,472	10

ANALYSIS OF EXPENDITURE (Note 3)

Expenditure Date	Expense Type	Details of expenditure	Currency	Amount (foreign currency)	Exchange Rate	Amount HKD
03-DEC-2025	Travelling - Airfare (Basic Economy Class)	Return economy airfare HKG-MEL, Qantas	HKD	7,860.00	1.0000	7,860.00
03-DEC-2025	Conference - Other Conference Expenses	Short course fee	AUD	480.00	5.1400	2,467.20
03-DEC-2025	Travelling - Accommodation	Clayton campus guest house, 3 nights	AUD	285.00	5.1400	1,464.90

SUBSISTENCE CLAIMED

Expense Type	From	To	Destination	Details	Nights	Amount HKD
Travelling - Subsistence Allowance	03-DEC-2025	06-DEC-2025	Australia - Melbourne	Meals and incidentals	3	1,680.00

NB. Cost centre to be confirmed with the departmental administrator before the claim is posted.

Name of Bank	Account Name	Account No	Sort Code
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Standard Chartered Bank (HK)	LAM KA YEE	003-882140-116	00-38-82
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Bank details are required only where they differ from those held on the payroll record (Note 4).

DECLARATION

I certify that the expenditure detailed above was incurred by me wholly, exclusively and necessarily in the course of University business, that the receipts attached are originals, and that no other claim has been or will be made in respect of these items.

Signature of Claimant Date

AUTHORISATION

I certify that funds are available against the cost centre shown and that this claim complies with the University's travel policy. The authorising signatory must be senior in status to the claimant.

Authorised by (PRINT & SIGNATURE) Date

Cost Centre	GL Code	WBS Element	SIO	VAT Code	Checked
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FOR FINANCE OFFICE USE ONLY — DESCRIPTION FOR POSTING TO AGRESSO

Note 1. State the business purpose of the travel in full. Claims giving only a destination will be returned.

Note 2. Categories are pre-printed. Leave a category blank where no expenditure was incurred against it.

Note 3. Where expenditure was incurred in a currency other than HKD, state the amount in the original currency together with the rate applied. The market rate published on the first day of travel may be used for the whole trip.

Note 4. Claims received more than 60 days after the end of travel must be accompanied by a written explanation.

EXPGEN2

University Finance Office

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Section 5. Receipts and Enclosures

The receipts for this claim are attached as originals behind the claim form and are not reproduced in this pack. The index below records what is enclosed, numbered to match the receipts table on the form. Amounts are on the receipts themselves.

No.	Supplier	Nature of receipt	Currency	Original / Electronic
1	Lufthansa	Airline e-ticket receipt, return economy	HKD	Electronic
2	Motel One Alexanderplatz	Hotel invoice, room and city tax	EUR	Original
3	Berliner Verkehrsbetriebe	Multi-day public transport pass	EUR	Original
4	DHL Express	Courier consignment to the host laboratory	EUR	Electronic
—	—	Subsistence: no receipts (flat rate)	—	—

5.1 Missing-receipt declaration (blank)

To be completed only where an original receipt cannot be produced. One declaration per item. The approver's countersignature is required for items of HK\$ 100 or more.

Item	Entry
Item number on the claim form	
Date of expense	
Supplier	
Nature of the expense	
Amount and currency	
Reason the receipt cannot be produced	
Claimant's signature and date	
Approver's countersignature and date	

5.2 Travel authorisation reference

The travel authorisation for this journey was approved in the finance system before booking. The authorisation number is quoted on the claim form under the claim reference and is checked by the Expenses Section against the system record; a claim whose authorisation cannot be found is returned.

Section 6. Approval Routing and Delegated Limits

A claim is routed by the cost centre it charges. The budget holder approves within the limit delegated to the post; a claim above the limit is escalated to the next level. Approvers must satisfy themselves that the travel was authorised, that each item is consistent with the policy, and that the arithmetic is correct.

Level	Post	Limit per claim (HK\$)	Escalates to
1	Principal investigator or cost centre manager	20,000	Head of department
2	Head of department	60,000	Dean of faculty
3	Dean of faculty	150,000	Director of Finance
4	Director of Finance	Unlimited	—

6.1 Cost centre directory (extract — faculties of Engineering and Science)

Cost centre	Unit	Budget holder post
14700	Department of Computer Science	Head of Department
14710	Computer Science — research grants pool	Associate Head (Research)
21350	Department of Industrial Engineering	Head of Department
21360	Industrial Engineering — laboratories	Laboratory Manager
30400	Department of Mechanical Engineering — teaching	Head of Department
30410	Mechanical Engineering — research grants pool	Associate Head (Research)
30430	Mechanical Engineering — laboratories	Laboratory Manager
30450	Mechanical Engineering — postgraduate programme	Programme Director
41200	Department of Physics	Head of Department
41220	Physics — research grants pool	Associate Head (Research)
52100	Department of Chemistry	Head of Department
52130	Chemistry — laboratories	Laboratory Manager
60010	Faculty of Engineering — Dean's office	Dean
60020	Faculty of Science — Dean's office	Dean

The full directory of 340 cost centres is in the finance system. A research grant has its own cost centre; travel funded by a grant is charged to that centre and approved by the principal investigator within level 1.

6.2 Cost centre directory — extended extract

Cost centre	Unit	Budget holder post	Cost centre	Unit	Budget holder post
10100	Office of the President	Chief of Staff	41230	Physics — laboratories	Laboratory Manager
10200	Vice-President (Research)	Director of Research Office	41250	Physics — postgraduate programme	Programme Director
10300	Vice-President (Administration)	Director of Administration	52110	Chemistry — research grants pool	Associate Head (Research)
11000	Registry	Registrar	52150	Chemistry — postgraduate programme	Programme Director
12000	Library	University Librarian	53100	Department of Biology	Head of Department
13000	Information Technology Services	Director of ITS	53110	Biology — research grants pool	Associate Head (Research)
14720	Computer Science — laboratories	Laboratory Manager	53130	Biology — field station	Station Manager
14750	Computer Science — postgraduate programme	Programme Director	54100	Department of Mathematics	Head of Department
15100	Department of Electrical Engineering	Head of Department	54110	Mathematics — research grants pool	Associate Head (Research)
15110	Electrical Engineering — research grants pool	Associate Head (Research)	60030	Faculty of Business — Dean's office	Dean
15130	Electrical Engineering —	Laboratory	60040	Faculty of Arts — Dean's office	Dean

	laboratories	Manager			
16100	Department of Civil Engineering	Head of Department	61100	Department of Economics	Head of Department
16110	Civil Engineering — research grants pool	Associate Head (Research)	61200	Department of Management	Head of Department
16130	Civil Engineering — structures laboratory	Laboratory Manager	62100	Department of English	Head of Department
17100	Department of Chemical Engineering	Head of Department	62200	Department of History	Head of Department
17110	Chemical Engineering — research grants pool	Associate Head (Research)	70100	Finance Office	Director of Finance
21370	Industrial Engineering — postgraduate programme	Programme Director	70200	Human Resources Office	Director of Human Resources
30440	Mechanical Engineering — machine shop	Workshop Manager	70300	Estates Office	Director of Estates
30460	Mechanical Engineering — undergraduate projects	Programme Director	70400	Communications Office	Director of Communications
30470	Mechanical Engineering — external collaborations	Associate Head (External)	80100	Research Institute for Advanced Materials	Institute Director
30480	Mechanical Engineering — equipment fund	Head of Department	80200	Research Institute for Data Science	Institute Director
30490	Mechanical Engineering — conference travel pool	Head of Department	80300	Centre for Sustainable Energy	Centre Director

Section 7. Standard Letters

The Expenses Section uses the following texts at each stage. Each letter carries the claim reference, the date and the name of the officer handling the claim.

7.1 Acknowledgement

Reference: [as shown on the acknowledgement] Date: [date of issue]

Dear Claimant,

Your travel expense claim was received by the Expenses Section on the date shown above and has been logged under the reference quoted. It will be checked within five working days and, if complete, forwarded for payment in the next payroll run.

If any item requires clarification we will write to you; otherwise no further action is needed on your part.

Yours sincerely,

Choi Su-min
Expenses Officer

7.2 Query

Reference: [as shown on the acknowledgement] Date: [date of issue]

Dear Claimant,

We have reviewed the claim referenced above and need the following before it can be approved:

1. The original receipt for the item listed on line 3 of the receipts table; the document enclosed is a booking confirmation, which does not show payment.
2. Confirmation of whether breakfast was included in the hotel rate, so that the subsistence claim can be checked.
3. The travel authorisation number, which is not quoted on the form.

Please reply within 14 days. The claim will be held in the meantime.

Yours sincerely,

Choi Su-min
Expenses Officer

7.3 Return for correction

Reference: [as shown on the acknowledgement] Date: [date of issue]

Dear Claimant,

The claim referenced above is returned for correction for the reason stated below. Please amend the form, initial the amendment, and resubmit through your departmental office.

Reason: the expense type entered for line 2 does not match the receipt. A hotel invoice is claimed as Travelling - Accommodation, not as Others.

A corrected claim re-enters the queue on the date it is received.

Yours sincerely,

Daniel Okoro
Senior Expenses Officer

7.4 Payment advice

Reference: [as shown on the acknowledgement] Date: [date of issue]

Dear Claimant,

The claim referenced above has been approved and will be paid to your salary account in the payroll run on the date shown. The amount paid is the total claimed less any advance and less any item disallowed; disallowed items and the reasons are listed on the enclosed statement.

If you disagree with a disallowance, Section 8 of the pack explains how to appeal.

Yours sincerely,

Daniel Okoro
Senior Expenses Officer

7.5 Advance approval

Reference: [as shown on the acknowledgement] Date: [date of issue]

Dear Claimant,

Your request for a travel advance against the authorisation referenced above has been approved. The amount will be paid to your salary account within three working days and must be accounted for on the expense claim submitted after the journey. Any balance not accounted for is repayable within 14 days of return.

Yours sincerely,

Choi Su-min
Expenses Officer

7.6 Notice of recovery

Reference: [as shown on the acknowledgement] Date: [date of issue]

Dear Claimant,

Following the audit of the claim referenced above, an amount has been identified as paid in error for the reason stated on the enclosed statement. Under Section 8.3 of the Travel and Expenses Policy the amount will be recovered by deduction from salary in equal instalments over the next three months, beginning with the next payroll run, unless you appeal within 30 days of the date of this letter.

Yours sincerely,

Daniel Okoro
Senior Expenses Officer

7.7 Late claim accepted

Reference: [as shown on the acknowledgement] Date: [date of issue]

Dear Claimant,

The claim referenced above was submitted more than 60 days after the return date. The head of department's written approval and your explanation of the delay have been received and accepted, and the claim has been passed for processing in the normal way. Please note that a claim submitted more than six months after the return date cannot be accepted.

Yours sincerely,

Choi Su-min
Expenses Officer

7.8 Appeal outcome

Reference: [as shown on the acknowledgement] Date: [date of issue]

Dear Claimant,

I have considered your appeal against the disallowance on the claim referenced above, together with the additional information you supplied. My decision and the reasons for it are set out below. Where the appeal is upheld in whole or in part, the amount will be paid in the next payroll run. A further appeal lies to the Vice-President (Administration) within 30 days.

Yours sincerely,

Director of Finance

Section 8. Audit, Compliance and Appeals

8.1 Checks applied to every claim

1. Identity: the name and staff number match the payroll record, and the claimant is an eligible person.
2. Authorisation: a travel authorisation exists for the journey and its dates.
3. Arithmetic: each line's reimbursable amount equals the receipt amount multiplied by the exchange rate, and the totals add up.
4. Receipts: every item other than a flat-rate allowance is supported by a receipt or a countersigned declaration.
5. Policy: class of travel, accommodation caps, subsistence rates and non-reimbursable items are applied.
6. Duplication: the claim does not repeat an item already reimbursed or invoiced directly to the University.

8.2 Sampling by Internal Audit

Internal Audit selects five percent of approved claims each quarter, weighted towards high-value claims and claims approved close to the delegated limit, and re-performs the checks above with reference to the underlying bookings. Findings are classified as clerical, policy or integrity. Clerical findings are corrected and noted; policy findings are reported to the head of department and any overpayment is recovered; integrity findings are referred to Human Resources.

8.3 Recovery

An overpayment is recovered by deduction from salary over not more than three months, after written notice to the claimant. A claimant who disputes the recovery may appeal under 8.4; recovery is suspended while the appeal is pending.

8.4 Appeals

A claimant who disagrees with a disallowance or a recovery may appeal in writing to the Director of Finance within 30 days of the payment advice or the notice of recovery, stating the item, the amount and the grounds. The Director of Finance responds within 20 working days. A further appeal lies to the Vice-President (Administration), whose decision is final.

8.5 Common findings

Finding	Frequency in last audit year	Usual cause
Booking confirmation submitted instead of receipt	High	Online booking platforms
Subsistence not reduced for meals provided	High	Conference packages
Wrong expense type	Medium	Registration fee claimed as Others
Exchange rate not to four decimals	Medium	Rate copied from a card statement
Claim submitted after 60 days	Medium	Fieldwork seasons
Personal days not separated	Low	Combined trips
Item invoiced directly also claimed	Low	Travel agent bookings

8.6 Retention of claim records

Approved claims and their receipts are scanned into the finance system and the paper originals are retained for seven years from the end of the financial year in which the claim was paid, or longer where a funder requires it. Grant-funded claims are retained for the period stated in the grant terms, which for some funders is ten years from the end of the project. Claimants do not need to keep their own copies but may find it useful to do so for tax purposes.

8.7 Tax treatment

Reimbursement of expenses necessarily incurred in the performance of duties is not income of the claimant and is not reported on the annual employer's return. Flat-rate allowances paid at or below the published rates are treated in the same way. Any amount paid above the published rate, or for an item that is not a business expense, is reported as income; the Expenses Section identifies such items on the payment advice.

8.8 Declaration of interests

A claimant who has a financial interest in a supplier used on a journey — for example a hotel or agency owned by a family member — must declare it on the claim form. The declaration does not by itself make the expense non-reimbursable, but the approver must confirm that the choice of supplier was reasonable.

8.9 Internal audit report extract — travel and expenses, previous audit year

Internal Audit reviewed a sample of 412 approved claims with a total value of HK\$ 6.8 million, selected from 8,240 claims paid in the year. The review re-performed the Expenses Section's checks and traced each sampled claim to the travel authorisation and to the bookings held by the appointed agent. The overall conclusion was that the control framework is adequate and operating effectively, with the exceptions noted below.

Area	Sample exceptions	Value (HK\$)	Classification	Action
Receipts	31 items supported by a booking confirmation only	48,200	Clerical	Reminder in departmental bulletin; portal upload guidance revised
Subsistence	24 claims not reduced for meals provided	9,600	Policy	Recovered; FAQ expanded
Timing	17 claims over 60 days without approval	—	Clerical	Approval obtained retrospectively
Expense type	12 items misclassified	—	Clerical	Glossary added to the pack
Class of travel	2 premium economy sectors without Dean's approval	6,400	Policy	Recovered; agent's booking control tightened
Duplication	1 hotel invoiced to the University and also claimed	3,150	Policy	Recovered
Integrity	None	—	—	—

Internal Audit recommended, and the Finance Office accepted, that the claim form be revised to carry a checklist on the reverse, that the monthly exchange rate table be included in the pack issued with each claim, and that the Expenses Section report quarterly to the Finance Committee on the number of claims returned for correction and the reasons. The first two recommendations are implemented in this version of the pack.

Section 9. Glossary

9.1 Expense types printed on the claim form

Expense type	Use for
Travelling - Airfare (Basic Economy Class)	Air tickets in economy class for a research visit, fieldwork or meeting, including taxes and booking fees
Travelling - Airfare (Other than Basic Economy Class)	Air tickets in any other class, with the authorising approval attached
Travelling - Accommodation	Hotel and other lodging on a research visit, fieldwork or meeting; room charge and taxes only
Travelling - Other Travelling Expenses	Local transport, transfers, transport passes, taxis, hire cars, fuel
Travelling - Subsistence Allowance	The flat daily rate for meals and incidentals on a research visit (subsistence table only)
Conference - Airfare (Basic Economy Class)	Air tickets in economy class where the purpose of the journey is a conference
Conference - Airfare (Other than Basic Economy Class)	Conference air tickets in any other class, with the authorising approval attached
Conference - Accommodation	Lodging during a conference; room charge and taxes only
Conference - Other Conference Expenses	Registration fees, poster printing, proceedings, conference dinner tickets where reimbursable
Conference - Subsistence Allowance	The flat daily rate for meals and incidentals during a conference
Others	Any item that fits no other type — shipping, visa fees, vaccinations, business telephone — with a full description

9.2 Terms used in correspondence

Term	Meaning
Advance	Cash issued before travel and deducted from the claim.
Approver	The budget holder who authorises the claim within the delegated limit.
Authorisation	Written approval of the journey obtained before booking.
Cap	The maximum nightly accommodation charge reimbursed for a destination.
Cost centre	The five-digit code of the unit or grant charged with the expense.
Disallowance	An item, or part of an item, not reimbursed, with the reason stated.
Flat rate	An allowance paid without receipts at a published rate.
Monthly rate	The exchange rate published by the Finance Office for a calendar month.
Night	A night spent away from Hong Kong on business, counted from departure to return.
Payroll run	The monthly payment cycle through which expenses are paid.
Receipt	A document from the supplier showing what was bought, when, and the amount paid.
Reimbursable amount	The receipt amount converted to Hong Kong dollars at the rate used.
Subsistence	Meals and incidental expenses while away overnight, paid at the flat rate.

Section 10. Contacts and Document Control

10.1 Contacts

Function	Contact	Hours
Expenses Section enquiries	expenses@univ.edu.hk; 3411 5200	Monday to Friday 9:00–17:30
Travel authorisation and advances	travel@univ.edu.hk; 3411 5210	Monday to Friday 9:00–17:30
Appointed travel agent (bookings)	3411 5299 (dedicated line)	Monday to Saturday 9:00–18:00
Payroll (payment queries)	payroll@univ.edu.hk; 3411 5100	Monday to Friday 9:00–17:30
Internal Audit	audit@univ.edu.hk	By appointment
Director of Finance (appeals)	In writing, Room 3.01, Administration Building	—

10.2 Document control

Version	Date	Change	Approved by
4.0	01/08/2022	Policy consolidated with rate tables into one pack	Finance Committee
4.1	01/01/2024	Subsistence rates revised; class of travel table added	Director of Finance
4.2	01/08/2024	Electronic submission pilot; FAQ added	Director of Finance
5.0	01/01/2026	Form EXPGEN2 revision; 2026 rates; monthly exchange rate table	Finance Committee

This pack is issued with a claim so that the form, the rules under which it is assessed and the supporting material are kept together. The claim form in Section 4 is the only part completed by the claimant; all other sections are for reference.

End of pack.

Section 11. Statement of Financial Responsibility

Every member of staff who incurs or approves expenditure on behalf of the University accepts the responsibilities set out in the Financial Regulations, of which this statement is an extract. The Regulations are available on the Finance Office intranet and prevail over this extract.

1. Expenditure may be incurred only for the purposes of the University, within an approved budget, and in accordance with the policies in force.
2. A person who incurs expenditure must obtain the authorisation required before committing the University, must obtain value for money, and must retain the evidence needed to support the expenditure.
3. A person who approves expenditure must be satisfied that it is proper, that it is within budget, and that the evidence is adequate, and must not approve expenditure in which he or she has a personal interest.
4. Any gift, hospitality or other benefit offered by a supplier in connection with University business must be declared in the register maintained by the department, and may be accepted only where it is modest and could not reasonably be seen to influence a decision.
5. Suspected fraud, theft or irregularity must be reported to the Director of Finance or through the University's confidential reporting line, and must not be investigated by the person who discovers it.
6. Breach of the Financial Regulations may be treated as misconduct under the disciplinary procedure and may result in the withdrawal of authority to incur or approve expenditure.

The claimant's signature on the expense claim form is a declaration that the claim complies with this statement and with the Travel and Expenses Policy.

Annex A — Hospitality, Entertainment and Gifts

Annex A.1 Purpose and Principles

This annex sets out when the University will meet the cost of hospitality offered to an external guest, how hosting a visitor should be planned and recorded, and how a gift given or received in the course of University business should be handled. It complements the Travel and Expenses Policy elsewhere in this pack rather than replacing it: where hospitality is incurred while travelling, the claim is still made on the form in this pack, but the additional information asked for here — who was hosted, why, and at what level of approval — is what turns an ordinary meal into properly authorised hospitality rather than a personal expense.

The underlying principle is simple even where individual situations are not: hospitality, entertainment and gifts paid for by the University are a legitimate part of doing business with external partners, but they are public funds spent on relationships rather than on goods or services received in return, and they attract a level of scrutiny — from auditors, from funders, and from the public — that an ordinary purchase does not. Staff extending or accepting hospitality are expected to be able to explain, in a sentence, why it served a genuine University purpose.

This annex is written around judgement rather than a fixed schedule of what may and may not be spent, because the range of situations in which hospitality arises is too wide for a schedule to cover sensibly. A member of staff planning an event that does not sit comfortably against any of the descriptions below is expected to ask the Head of Department before proceeding rather than to pick whichever description seems closest and hope it holds up to later scrutiny; asking beforehand is never held against the person who asks.

Annex A.2 When Business Hospitality Is Allowed

Hospitality is allowed where it supports a genuine University purpose: building or maintaining a relationship with an external partner, discussing a collaboration, marking the conclusion of a piece of joint work, or extending ordinary courtesy to a visitor who has given their time to the University. It is not a substitute for a colleague's own subsistence while travelling, which is claimed under the ordinary rate rather than as hospitality, and it is not extended to a University colleague from the same department in the ordinary course of work, since that is not what the hospitality budget is for.

The person proposing to host a guest decides, before the event, roughly how many guests will attend, what kind of setting is appropriate to the purpose, and what level of spend is proportionate. A modest meal or a round of refreshments needs no more than the Head of Department's agreement in advance or as soon as practicable afterwards; a larger or more elaborate event, or one involving a guest from a government body or a regulator, is agreed in advance with the Dean, because the appearance of the event matters as much as its actual cost.

A member of staff paying personally for hospitality and later seeking reimbursement should have the same approval in place as if the University had paid the supplier directly; approval given only after the event is granted less readily, and never as a matter of course, because the point of prior agreement is to allow a different level of hospitality to be suggested before money has been spent, not to provide a formality afterwards.

Annex A.3 Alcohol

A modest amount of alcohol served with a meal for an external guest is treated as part of the hospitality rather than as a separate item, provided it is proportionate to the meal and the occasion. It is not offered where a guest's own institution or role means it would be inappropriate, and it is not charged where a

University colleague is present without an external guest, since that is not hospitality in the sense this annex describes.

An event held mainly around alcohol, rather than a meal at which alcohol is incidental, needs the Dean's agreement in advance regardless of its scale, and is not appropriate at all where a guest is a serving public official whose own organisation restricts what they may accept. Staff arranging hospitality for a visitor from a public body are expected to check, if they are not sure, what that visitor's own rules allow, rather than assume that what is normal for the University is normal for the guest.

A member of staff is never expected or encouraged to drink alcohol as part of extending hospitality, and a guest's choice not to drink is treated as entirely unremarkable and never commented upon. Where a student is present at an event involving alcohol — for example a postgraduate research student invited to a working dinner with a visiting collaborator — the same standard of moderation applies, and the Head of Department hosting the event is responsible for judging that the setting remains appropriate throughout.

Annex A.4 Hosting External Visitors

A visit by an external partner, prospective collaborator, examiner or invited speaker is usually planned by the department some time in advance, and the hospitality attached to it — a working meal, refreshments around a seminar or a site visit, a modest dinner marking the end of a longer visit — is approved as part of that planning rather than arranged at the last minute. Where a visit is hosted jointly by more than one department, one of them takes responsibility for the hospitality budget and the approval, so that the same event is not authorised twice or falls through the gap between two departments each assuming the other has dealt with it.

1. Agree the purpose of the visit and the guests to be hosted before the visit is confirmed.
2. Decide the appropriate scale of hospitality for the purpose and the guests, and record it on the hospitality approval note.
3. Obtain the Head of Department's agreement, or the Dean's where the visit falls into one of the categories described above.
4. Keep the itemised receipt and record the names and affiliations of the guests hosted.
5. Enter the event in the hospitality register within the period set out in Annex A.7.

Where a visitor is hosted over more than one day, the department plans the hospitality across the whole visit rather than treating each meal as a separate decision, so that the combined level of spending can be judged against the purpose of the visit as a whole. A visit that turns out to need a materially higher level of hospitality than was first agreed — because, for example, additional guests are invited at short notice — is brought back to whoever gave the original approval before the additional spending is committed, not reported afterwards as a variation.

Annex A.5 Gifts Given by the University

A gift given to an external contact — a visiting speaker, a long-standing partner, a retiring collaborator from another institution — is kept modest and connected to a specific, identifiable occasion; it is not given as a routine accompaniment to every visit or meeting. A small token appropriate to a first visit or a courtesy call needs only the Head of Department's agreement; anything beyond a token, or a gift proposed for a repeated or ongoing relationship, is agreed with the Director of Finance before it is bought, since the same relationship can otherwise accumulate a pattern of gifts that no single approval has ever looked at as a whole.

A gift funded by a specific grant or donation is subject to whatever the funder's own terms allow in addition to this annex, and where the two are in tension the stricter of the two applies. A gift is never

given in a form that could reasonably be understood as a personal benefit to the recipient rather than a courtesy connected to the University relationship — cash or a cash-equivalent voucher is not given as a gift under this annex in any circumstance.

Where a department wishes to give a gift bearing the University's own crest or branding, the item is sourced through the channel the University maintains for this purpose rather than commissioned independently, both to keep the standard of what is given consistent and because that channel already accounts for the University's own guidance on how its name and crest may be used on an item leaving the campus.

Annex A.6 Gifts Received by Staff

A member of staff offered a gift by an external party because of their University role considers, before accepting it, whether accepting would be seen to affect — or to risk appearing to affect — a decision they are involved in, such as a procurement choice, an admission decision, or the award of a contract. A modest gift connected to a specific courtesy, such as a token given at the end of a visit consistent with the visitor's own culture or practice, may usually be accepted and simply declared; a gift of any significant value, or one offered in connection with a decision the recipient is currently involved in, is not accepted personally.

Where a gift cannot reasonably be declined without causing offence — a common situation with an overseas visitor whose own custom expects a gift to be accepted — the recipient accepts it on the University's behalf rather than their own, declares it promptly, and, where it is of more than modest value, arranges for it to be shared, displayed in a common area, or otherwise treated as belonging to the department rather than to the individual. Doubt about whether a particular gift needs to be declared is resolved by declaring it; a declaration that turns out not to have been necessary causes no difficulty, while a gift that should have been declared and was not can look very different in hindsight.

A series of small gifts from the same external party, each individually modest enough that declaring any one of them on its own would seem excessive, is looked at differently once the pattern becomes apparent, because it is the accumulated relationship rather than any single item that raises a question. A member of staff who notices that gifts from the same source have become a regular occurrence is expected to mention this to the Head of Department even before any single gift would obviously need to be declared, so that the pattern can be considered as a whole rather than one item at a time.

Annex A.7 The Register of Interests

Hospitality given above a modest level, gifts given, gifts received, and any other benefit that could reasonably be seen to influence a staff member's University duties are recorded in the register of interests maintained by the Registrar's office. An entry is made within ten working days of the event, the gift, or the offer, whichever is relevant, and includes enough detail — who was involved, the approximate value, and the University purpose — for someone reviewing the register later to understand why the entry is there without needing to ask the person who made it.

The register is reviewed by the Registrar's office twice a year, and a pattern that appears only when entries are read together — hospitality that keeps recurring with the same external party, or a member of staff whose name appears unusually often — is raised with the relevant Dean even where no single entry, read on its own, would have caused concern. Staff are expected to treat the register as a working record rather than as a formality completed reluctantly; an accurate and timely register is one of the University's main defences if a hospitality or gift arrangement is later questioned from outside.

Reference: [as shown on the acknowledgement] Date: [date of issue]

Notice to Heads of Department and Deans

From the Registrar's Office

Register of interests: a reminder before the year-end review

As the twice-yearly review of the register of interests approaches, departments are asked to check that hospitality above the modest level described in this annex, and any gift given or received, has been entered promptly rather than left until the review is due. An entry made close to the deadline is not a problem in itself, but a run of entries backdated by several months makes it harder for this office to see whether the register reflects what actually happened at the time. Where a department is not sure whether something needed to be entered at all, please ask before the review rather than deciding not to enter it.

Registrar's Office

Annex A.8 Sponsorship and External Funding of Events

Where an external party offers to meet some or all of the cost of a University event — a lecture, a public seminar, a networking reception — the offer is treated as sponsorship rather than as an ordinary donation, and is agreed in advance with the Director of Finance regardless of the amount involved, because sponsorship raises questions of independence that a straightforward gift of money does not. The department organising the event decides the content and the guest list on its own terms before an approach is made to a potential sponsor, so that the sponsorship follows the event rather than shaping it.

A sponsor's name or logo may be acknowledged on materials connected with the event in a manner proportionate to the support given, but a sponsor is not given a role in deciding who speaks, who is invited, or what is said, and a sponsorship agreement that would require this is not accepted. Where a member of staff has a personal connection to the proposed sponsor — a family relationship, a former employment, a business interest — that connection is declared to the Head of Department before the approach is made, in the same way as any other interest under Annex A.7.

Repeat sponsorship from the same external party, across more than one event or more than one year, is reviewed by the Director of Finance to confirm that the relationship as a whole still looks appropriate, even where each individual event was approved correctly at the time. A department that expects to approach the same sponsor again is encouraged to raise this at the point of the first approval rather than let the pattern emerge unplanned.

Annex A.9 Jointly Hosted Events and Shared Costs

An event hosted jointly with another institution, a professional body, or an alumni group often involves shared costs that do not map neatly onto the hospitality approval described elsewhere in this annex. Before such an event is agreed, the department organising the University's side confirms in writing with the co-host who is paying for what — the venue, the catering, any speaker costs, any gift or memento — so that neither side pays twice for the same item and neither leaves an item unpaid on the assumption that the other has covered it.

Where the University's share of a jointly hosted event includes hospitality above the modest level described in Annex A.2, that share is approved through the same route as if the University were hosting alone, using the University's own share of the cost as the figure against which the approval threshold is judged, not the total cost of the event including the co-host's contribution. The event as a whole, including the co-host's contribution, is nonetheless described in the hospitality register entry so that the record reflects what actually happened.

A jointly hosted event that recurs on a regular basis — an annual lecture, a standing seminar series run with the same partner — is reviewed by the Head of Department at least once a year to confirm that the

cost-sharing arrangement agreed at the outset still reflects what each side actually contributes, since an arrangement that made sense at the first event can drift without anyone deciding that it should.

A co-host that is itself a commercial organisation, rather than another academic or public body, is treated with the additional care described for sponsorship in Annex A.8, even where the arrangement is framed as a joint event rather than as sponsorship in the strict sense. The Director of Finance is the person to ask where it is not clear which framing better describes a particular proposal.

Annex A.10 Recording and Retention of Hospitality Records

The itemised receipt, the note of who was hosted and why, and the record of approval for an item of hospitality are kept together, whether the item was paid directly by the University or by a member of staff seeking reimbursement through the claim form in this pack. Where hospitality is claimed as an expense, the same receipt supports both the expense claim and the hospitality register entry, and does not need to be produced twice in two different forms.

Hospitality and gift records are retained for the same period as other financial records connected with a claim, and for longer where a gift or a sponsorship arrangement is connected to a grant with its own retention requirement. Internal Audit may review hospitality and gift records as part of the wider sampling described elsewhere in this pack, and a department that cannot produce the approval or the register entry for an item under review is likely to be asked to explain the gap even where the underlying spending was entirely reasonable.

Annex A.11 Approval Routes

The approval needed for hospitality, for a gift, or for entertaining an external visitor depends on the scale of what is proposed and, in some cases, on who is being hosted, rather than on a fixed spending limit alone. As a general pattern, the Head of Department approves routine hospitality and modest gifts connected to normal departmental business; the Dean's agreement is needed for a larger event, for hospitality involving a guest from a public body, or for a gift proposed as part of an ongoing relationship; and the Director of Finance or the Vice-President (Administration) is involved where a proposal touches a sponsorship arrangement, a repeated pattern of spending with the same external party, or a level of spending that a Head of Department would not normally be expected to authorise alone.

Situation	Approver	Refer upward when	Record required
Hospitality for an external visitor within the departmental guideline	Head of Department	Cost exceeds the departmental guideline for the occasion	Hospitality register entry
Hospitality where alcohol is served	Head of Department	A guest is a serving public official or a regulator	Hospitality register entry noting the alcohol served
Gift given to an external contact	Head of Department	Value exceeds the standard token gift level	Gift register entry
Gift received from an external party	Reported to Head of Department	The gift cannot reasonably be declined or shared	Entry in the register of interests
Hospitality repeated with the same external party	Head of Department	A pattern of recurring hospitality emerges	Note in the register of interests
Hospitality linked to a sponsorship arrangement	Director of Finance	Any proposal of this kind	Entry in the register of interests and the hospitality register

Where it is not obvious which route applies — a visit that starts as a routine courtesy call and grows into something larger, for example, or a gift offered unexpectedly during a visit that was not planned as an occasion for one — the safer course is to ask the next level up rather than to assume the lower approval was enough. The Registrar's office and the Director of Finance would both rather answer a question about which route applies than find, at the twice-yearly review, an entry that nobody quite remembers agreeing to.

Where a Head of Department is themselves the one proposing to host or to accept a gift, the approval that would otherwise fall to them is given instead by the Dean, and where a Dean is the one concerned, it moves to the Vice-President (Administration). This is not a comment on any individual's judgement; it exists because no one approves their own hospitality or their own gift, in the same way that no one signs off their own expense claim under the arrangements described elsewhere in this pack.

Annex A.12 Cultural and Religious Considerations

A guest's dietary requirements, whether religious, cultural, medical or simply personal, are established when the invitation is issued rather than discovered at the table, and a venue or menu is chosen that can accommodate them without singling the guest out. Where a guest does not drink alcohol for religious or personal reasons, a proportionate non-alcoholic option is offered as a matter of course rather than as an afterthought, and no guest is pressed to accept a drink they have declined.

Gift-giving customs vary considerably between cultures, and what would be a generous, well-judged gesture in one context can be either an embarrassment or, in some public-sector contexts, a genuine problem for the recipient in another. A member of staff hosting a visitor from an unfamiliar background, or planning to give a gift during a visit abroad, is encouraged to ask a colleague familiar with that context, or the Registrar's office, before deciding what would be appropriate, rather than to guess. The same caution applies to the number, the wrapping, and the manner of presenting a gift, all of which can carry meaning that is easy to miss from outside the custom.

None of this is a reason to avoid hospitality or gift-giving with an unfamiliar guest; it is a reason to ask a short question in advance. Getting this right is treated as an ordinary part of preparing for a visit, in the same way as confirming dietary needs or checking a guest's preferred title, and not as a specialist undertaking reserved for a particular office.

Annex A.13 Hospitality for Prospective Students and Their Families

An open day, an offer-holder event, or a visit by a prospective student and an accompanying family member is hospitality of a different character from hospitality extended to an established external partner, and is approved and recorded a little differently as a result. Refreshments provided as part of a published open day programme, available to all attendees rather than a specific individual, are treated as an event cost approved by the Head of Department when the programme is planned, rather than as an individual hospitality decision for each family that attends.

Where a department wishes to host a smaller, more personal meeting with a particular prospective student and their family — for example a scholarship candidate being considered for an award of some standing — that is treated as ordinary hospitality under Annex A.2, with the same approval and the same register entry, because it is a hospitality decision about specific, named guests rather than a general event cost. Staff are reminded that hospitality of this kind is extended because of the prospective student's own standing and promise, not because of who their family is or what they might be able to offer the University in another capacity; where the latter appears to be a factor, the matter is referred to the Dean before any hospitality is offered.

Annex A.14 Declining Hospitality and Recording a Refusal

Declining an offer of hospitality or a gift is as legitimate an outcome of this annex as accepting one, and a member of staff who judges that accepting would be inappropriate, even where a stricter reading of the rules above might have allowed it, is supported in that judgement rather than second-guessed for having been more cautious than required. Where a member of staff is uncertain in the moment, declining and asking about it afterwards is always an acceptable course, and is preferable to accepting something that later turns out to have needed a higher approval than was available at the time.

A gift or invitation that is declined because of a live conflict of interest — for example an offer made by a party involved in a procurement process the staff member is currently running — is noted in the register of interests in the same way as an accepted gift would be, since the fact that an offer was made and refused can be just as relevant to a later question about the process as a gift that was accepted would have been. The note records what was offered, by whom, and that it was declined, without needing the same level of approval that an acceptance would have required.

A pattern of declined offers from the same external party is treated with the same attention as a pattern of accepted ones: if a supplier or partner repeatedly offers hospitality or gifts that have to be declined, the Head of Department may wish to raise directly with that party that such offers are not appropriate, both to avoid the awkwardness of repeated refusal and to protect the relationship from an appearance of impropriety that need never have arisen.

None of this is intended to make ordinary courtesy feel fraught. The overwhelming majority of hospitality offered and accepted across the University in the course of a year raises no question at all, and this annex exists to protect that ordinary, unremarkable majority from being crowded out by the small number of situations each year that genuinely do need a closer look.

